

the standpoint which we now occupy, we may even consider ourselves absolved from such an examination. All the foregoing has brought to light clearly enough the independence of Israel's religion in general and of the later Judaic development in particular. The birth and earliest history of Judaism have been explained in this and the previous chapter quite naturally, without any necessity for calling in the influence of Parseeism to our aid. Moreover, those who, on the ground of the resemblance between the two religions, make the one dependent on the other, must not shut their eyes to the no less great, nay, material difference—which is surely palpable enough. We will not dwell any longer, therefore, upon this opinion, which, besides, is now altogether obsolete.

It is quite otherwise with regard to a remark made by the author of "The Religion of Zarathustra," to whom we have just referred. He draws attention to the great affinity between the organization of the Jewish synagogue and the Persian worship. "The sacrifices and other sacred ceremonies of the Parsees were not tied down to a fixed religious centre; they were performed in all places, on every holy hill. Ezra did not follow this example and respected the ancient Israelitish tradition, only permitting the sacrificial service in the temple at Jerusalem. Places of worship, however, in which the faithful offered up prayer in common, sang religious songs and read the books of the law or the prophets, he established all over the land; and it would seem that this salutary reformation was an imitation of the custom of the Parsees to read the sacred books before the Mazdayacnians, to repeat the ancient prayers before them, and to sing the holy songs before them or with them, at stated times."* One might assent to this entirely, without thereby detracting in any way from the independence of Judaism. But that assent can only be given with some limitation. We found, namely, that the synagogue cannot be regarded as a foreign plant; it was born on foreign

* Tiele, l. c., p. 283.